

MENSA

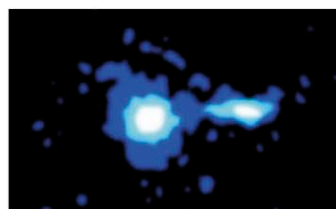
THE TABLE MOUNTAIN

THE FAINTEST CONSTELLATION OF ALL, MENSA IS NEAR THE SOUTH CELESTIAL POLE. THE LARGE MAGELLANIC CLOUD IS ON ITS BORDER WITH DORADO.

Small and faint, Mensa was devised by French astronomer Nicolas Louis de Lacaille. He named it "Mons Mensae" after Table Mountain, near Cape Town, South Africa, close to where he observed the southern skies in the 1750s. Mensa is the only one of the 14 constellations he defined that is not a scientific or artistic tool. Its most notable feature is the part of the Large Magellanic Cloud that Mensa includes.

► Quasar PKS 0637-752

This high-luminosity quasar is 6 billion light-years away and can only be studied using space-based telescopes. It radiates with the power of 10 trillion Suns from a region smaller than our Solar System. Its energy source is a supermassive black hole at its heart.



Large Magellanic Cloud
A disrupted barred spiral galaxy visible to the naked eye. It is 180,000 light-years away and orbits the Milky Way

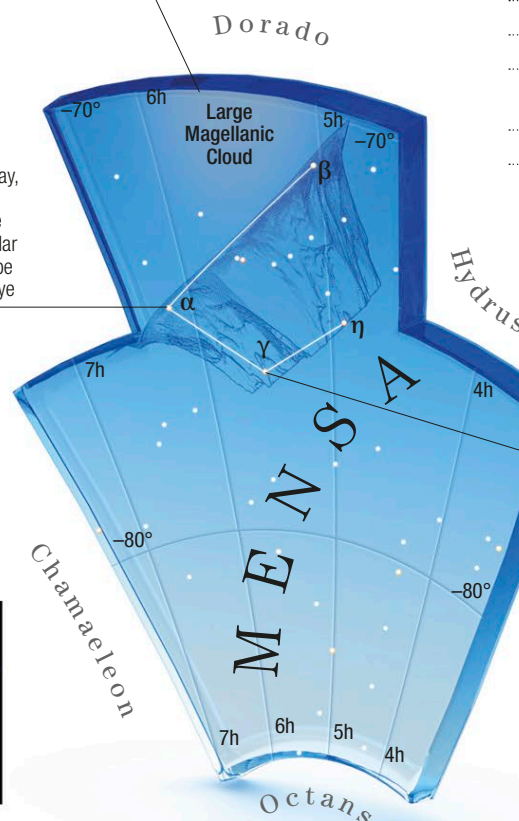
Alpha (α) Mensae
At 33 light-years away, this yellow main-sequence star is one of the few stars similar to the Sun that can be seen by the naked eye

KEY DATA

Size ranking	75
Brightest stars	Alpha (α) 5.1, Gamma (γ) 5.2
Genitive	Mensae
Abbreviation	Men
Highest in sky at 10pm	December–February
Fully visible	5°N–90°S



CHART 2



Gamma (γ) Mensae
With Eta (η), this orange giant marks the flat top of the mountain. It is magnitude 5.2 and 102 light-years from Earth

OCTANS

THE OCTANT

LOCATED IN A BARREN AREA OF SKY, OCTANS ENCOMPASSES THE SOUTH CELESTIAL POLE AND CONTAINS FEW SIGNIFICANT CELESTIAL OBJECTS.

Devised in the 1750s by the French astronomer Nicolas Louis de Lacaille, this constellation was named for the then recently invented navigational instrument and forerunner to the better-known sextant, the octant. Its most notable feature is Sigma Octantis, the nearest naked-eye star to the South Celestial Pole. Gamma Octantis is a chain of three unrelated stars, two yellow and one orange giant, usually able to be distinguished by the naked eye.

Nu (ν) Octantis
An orange giant and Octans' brightest star. It is magnitude 3.8 and 72 light-years away

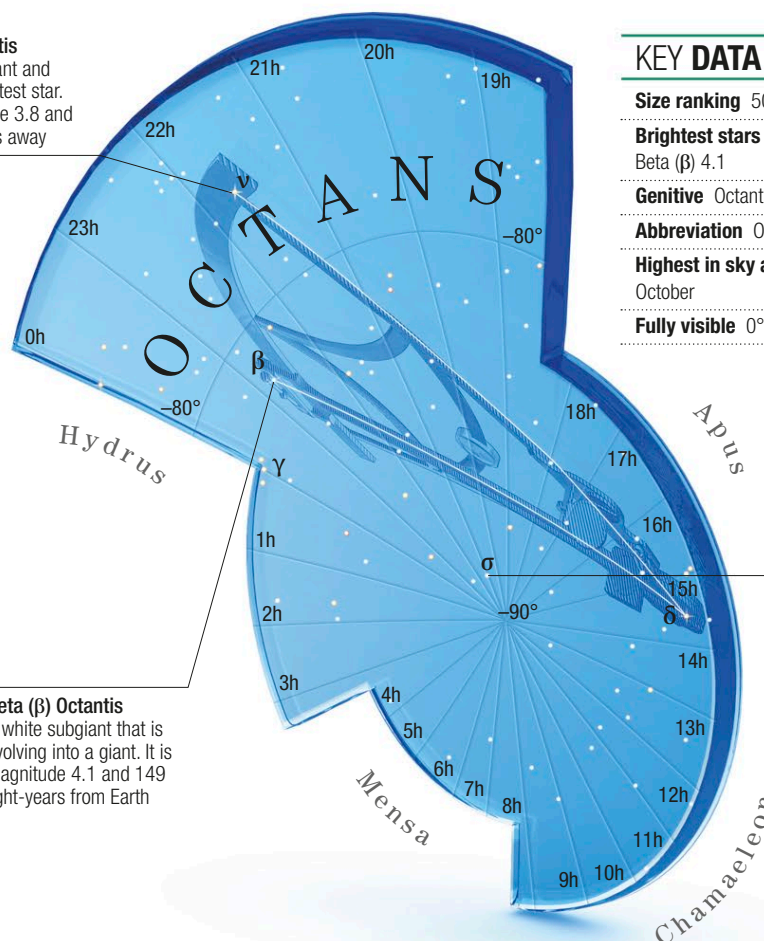
Beta (β) Octantis
A white subgiant that is evolving into a giant. It is magnitude 4.1 and 149 light-years from Earth

KEY DATA

Size ranking	50
Brightest stars	Nu (ν) 3.8, Beta (β) 4.1
Genitive	Octantis
Abbreviation	Oct
Highest in sky at 10pm	October
Fully visible	0°N–90°S



CHART 2



Sigma (σ) Octantis
This yellow-white subgiant lies within 1° of the South Celestial Pole. It is of magnitude 5.4 and is 280 light-years from Earth